

1. The Monkey and the Crocodile

The Moral: Presence of mind can save you from any danger.

Once upon a time, a clever monkey lived on a beautiful jamun (berry) tree by the side of a river. The tree bore the sweetest fruit. In the river lived a crocodile and his wife.

The monkey and the crocodile became great friends. The monkey would toss down sweet berries for the crocodile to eat. One day, the crocodile took some berries home to his wife. She loved them but said, "If the berries are this sweet, imagine how sweet the monkey's heart must be! I want to eat his heart."

The crocodile was sad but finally agreed to trick his friend. He went to the monkey and said, "Friend, my wife has invited you for dinner. Hop on my back, and I will carry you to our home."

The monkey happily jumped on the crocodile's back. When they reached the middle of the river, the crocodile began to sink. "I am sorry," he said, "but my wife wants to eat your heart."

The monkey didn't panic. He said, "Oh! Why didn't you tell me sooner? I keep my heart safely in a hollow in the tree. Let's go back and get it."

The foolish crocodile believed him and swam back. As soon as they reached the shore, the monkey climbed high up the tree and said, "You ungrateful friend! Does anyone keep their heart outside their body? Go away and never come back!"

2. The Tortoise and the Geese

The Moral: Think before you speak, and always listen to the advice of friends.

A tortoise named Kambugriva lived in a lake and was friends with two geese. They spent all their time together telling stories.

One year, there was a drought, and the lake began to dry up. The geese said, "We must fly to another lake, or we will die." The tortoise wanted to go too, but he couldn't fly.

They came up with a plan: The two geese would hold a stick in their beaks, and the tortoise would hold onto the middle of the stick with his mouth. "But remember," warned the geese, "you must not open your mouth for any reason, or you will fall."

As they flew over a town, people looked up in wonder. "Look at that! Geese carrying a tortoise!" they shouted.

The tortoise got angry and wanted to tell the people to mind their own business. As soon as he opened his mouth to speak, he let go of the stick and fell straight down to the ground.

3. The Loyal Mongoose

The Moral: Never act in haste; think before you do something you might regret.

A farmer and his wife had a small baby. They also had a pet mongoose who was very loyal and loved the baby.

One day, the mother had to go to the market. She asked her husband to watch the baby, but he also had to go to the fields for a short while. He left the baby sleeping in the cradle, trusting the mongoose to guard him.

While they were away, a large black snake crawled into the house and headed toward the baby's cradle. The brave mongoose jumped on the snake and, after a long fight, killed it.

When the mother returned, the mongoose ran to the door to greet her. Seeing blood on the mongoose's mouth and paws, the mother panicked. "You have killed my baby!" she screamed. In her anger, she threw a heavy water pot at the mongoose, killing him instantly.

She rushed inside and found the baby sleeping peacefully. On the floor next to the cradle lay the dead snake, torn to pieces. The mother realized her terrible mistake and wept for the loyal friend she had lost due to her haste.